Game concept & rulebook · Paper prototype v2



Curse of Blackthorn Keep

Cursed Castle · Cursed Knight · Legendary Sword

A single-player dark-fantasy survival board game. Search a cursed castle for Rune Shards, restore three Ancient Seals and awaken the sword Dragonbane before the Cursed Knight finds you.

1	10–15	1 × D6	~2 MIN
player	minutes	one six-sided die	to learn

University paper-game assignment · Built to be played with an A4 map, printed cards, paper tokens and one die

01

Game Concept

You are trapped alone inside Blackthorn Keep. A Cursed Knight walks its halls. The only way out is to break the curse that binds it.

The story

Blackthorn Keep was once guarded by a loyal knight and the legendary sword **Dragonbane**. When the sword's power was sealed away, a curse fell over the castle. The knight's soul was bound to its armour, and it now patrols the keep forever, hunting anyone who enters.

Three **Ancient Seals** hidden in the castle hold Dragonbane's power. Restore all three with magical **Rune Shards** and the sword awakens, the curse breaks, and you escape.

The goal

Restore **Seal A**, **Seal B** and **Seal C** before your Health reaches 0 or Turn 24 ends. Each Seal costs 2 Rune Shards, so you need at least 6.

Genre & inspiration

Single-player survival-horror strategy. It is inspired by the tension of *Final Girl* and simple "draw 2, choose 1" card games.

Design pillars

Tension. The Knight is always somewhere close. Every noise you make can bring it to you.

Meaningful choices. Each turn you keep one card and throw one away: fast but loud, or slow but safe?

Fair luck. One die adds risk, but no single bad roll ends the game. You lose from piled-up risk.

A readable enemy. The Knight is never random about *where* it goes, so you can learn it and outsmart it.

Paper-first. Every rule can be done by hand with cards, tokens and one D6.

The core loop

1 · EXPLORE

Move through the castle toward the Seals while keeping away from the Knight.

2 · GATHER

SEARCH rooms for Rune Shards. A lucky 6 also finds a Minor Treasure.

3 · RESTORE

ACTIVATE a Seal with 2 Shards. Failure makes Noise, and Noise draws the Knight.

The NPC: the Cursed Knight

The Cursed Knight is the game's only NPC. It is an enemy controlled by simple, fixed rules, so a human player never has to make its decisions. It walks a guard route when the castle is quiet, goes to investigate the last noise you made, and hunts you directly when you are loud. A die decides *whether* it moves. Its behaviour decides *where*. This makes it feel like a believable guard that reacts to you, not a random monster.

02

Components & Setup

Components

Item	Qty	Notes
Castle map (A4)	1	3 × 3 rooms with doorways
Action Cards	16	5 Explore, 4 Search, 3 Activate, 2 Dash, 2 Hide
Hero cards	4	Ranger, Knight, Mage, Alchemist
Minor Treasure cards	4	Charm, Shield, Ration, Map
Player & Knight pieces	2	One each
Noise Location token	1	Marks the Last Known Noise Location
Seal "Restored" tokens	3	Red A, Blue B, Green C
Tracker sheet	1	Health, Shards, Noise, Turn, Dragonbane
Markers	5	Health, Rune Shards, Noise, Turn, and a patrol-direction arrow
Six-sided die (D6)	1	

The castle map



Rooms connect only to rooms that share a side. No diagonal moves, no teleporting.

Setup

1. **Choose your hero** and take its card and its single starting item (see section 06).
2. Set the trackers: **Health 3**, **Rune Shards 0**, **Noise 0**, **Turn 1**. All three Seals start **CORRUPTED**, and all three Dragonbane circles start empty (○).
3. Place your piece in the **Great Hall** and the Cursed Knight in the **Dungeon**. Point the patrol-direction marker **forward** (toward Seal C).
4. Keep the Noise Location token **off the map**. There is no noise yet.
5. Shuffle the 16 Action Cards face down. Shuffle the 4 Minor Treasure cards into a separate face-down pile.

You win the moment the third Seal is restored. **You lose** if your Health reaches 0, or if Turn 24 ends before all three Seals are restored.

03

Playing a Turn

Every turn follows the same 13 steps, in this order.

1. YOUR TURN — **Draw 2 Action Cards.** If the deck is empty, shuffle the discard pile into a new deck first.
2. YOUR TURN — **Choose 1** card to play. You may use an item first.
3. YOUR TURN — **Discard** the other card.
4. YOUR TURN — **Resolve** your chosen action.
5. YOUR TURN — **Roll the D6** if the action needs it (Search, Activate).
6. YOUR TURN — **Update Noise** on the tracker.
7. KNIGHT — **Check the Knight's behaviour:** Patrol, Investigate or Hunt.
8. KNIGHT — **Roll the Knight's D6.** 1–4 stays · 5–6 moves 1 room.
9. KNIGHT — **Move the Knight** 1 room if it rolled 5–6.
10. CHECK — **Encounter:** if you and the Knight share a room, resolve it (section 05).
11. CHECK — **Victory:** all 3 Seals restored? You win.
12. CHECK — **Defeat:** Health 0, or this was Turn 24? You lose.
13. NEXT — **Next turn:** move the Turn marker up 1 and start again.

Running out of Action Cards never makes you lose. The only time limit is Turn 24. Both cards from each turn (played and unplayed) go to the discard pile.

The Action Cards

Explore	Dash	Search	Activate	Hide
× 5	× 2	× 4	× 3	× 2

Explore

Move to 1 room that shares a side with yours.

Dash

Move through up to 2 connected rooms. You choose the route and may stop after 1. After moving, Noise +1, and the room where you stop becomes the **Last Known Noise Location**: put the Noise token there.

Hide (action card)

Noise –1, to a minimum of 0. This is not the same as HIDE during an encounter.

Search

ROLL	RESULT
1	Search fails. +1 Noise. This room becomes the Last Known Noise Location.
2–3	Gain 1 Rune Shard.
4–5	Gain 2 Rune Shards.
6	Gain 2 Rune Shards **and** draw 1 Minor Treasure.

Activate

You can only play Activate if **all three** are true:

- You are standing on Seal A, B or C.
- That Seal is not already restored.
- You have at least 2 Rune Shards.

ROLL	RESULT
1–2	Activation fails. +1 Noise. **Keep** your Shards. This Seal room becomes the Last Known Noise Location.
3–5	Success. Spend 2 Shards. The Seal is **RESTORED** ✓.
6	Success. Spend 2 Shards. The Seal is restored, and –1 Noise.

Rune Shards are **only** spent when an activation succeeds. Each Seal can be restored only once. When you restore a Seal, mark its Dragonbane circle: ○ → ✨. When all three are ✨, **Dragonbane awakens** and you win immediately.

> **No playable card?** If both cards are Activate and you can't use them, discard both and pass your action. The Knight still takes its turn.

04

Noise & the Cursed Knight

Noise (0–5)

Noise is how easily the Knight can find you. It never goes below 0 or above 5.

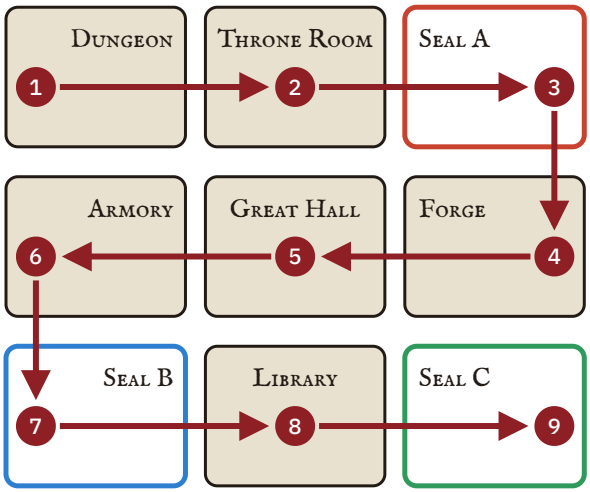
RAISES NOISE	
Dash	+1
Failed Search (roll 1)	+1
Failed Activate (roll 1–2)	+1
RUN during an encounter	+1
LOWERS NOISE	
Hide action card	−1
Silence Scroll (Mage)	−2
Ward Charm (treasure)	−1
Activate roll of 6	−1

Last Known Noise Location

Whenever you **raise** Noise, move the Noise token to the room you are in after the action. Only the newest noise counts, so the token always shows your latest noise.

Noise 5 gives the Knight no extra movement. It works exactly like Noise 3–4.

Patrol route



Dungeon → Throne Room → Seal A → Forge → Great Hall → Armory → Seal B → Ancient Library → Seal C. At Seal C it turns around and walks the route backwards to the Dungeon, then turns again. Flip the patrol-direction marker at each end.

The Knight's three behaviours

Check this at step 7 every turn. The Knight's direction is **never random**.

Patrol

`Noise 0–2 and no Noise token on the map`

Follows its fixed guard route (below), one room at a time.

Investigate

`Noise 0–2 and the Noise token is on the map`

Moves toward the Noise token by the shortest route. If it arrives and you are not there, remove the token and it goes back to Patrol.

Hunt

`Noise 3–5`

It knows your room. It ignores the patrol and the token and moves toward you by the shortest route.

Losing the trail. When Noise falls from 3 or more to 2 or less, the Knight loses track of you. Put the Noise token on your current room. The Knight now **Investigates** where it last knew you were.

Knight movement

KNIGHT D6	RESULT
1–4	The Knight **stays**.
5–6	The Knight moves **1 room** in the direction its behaviour says.

The die only decides **move or stay**. The Knight never moves 2 rooms from its roll.

Shortest route, no guessing

When hunting or investigating, the Knight takes the shortest legal route. If two routes are equally short, it moves **vertically first** (up or down), then horizontally.

Example: the Knight is in the Dungeon and you are at Seal C. It moves down to the Armory first, not right to the Throne Room.

Coming back to Patrol

After investigating or hunting, the Knight continues the patrol from whatever room it is in, still facing the direction on the patrol marker.

Stunned

A stunned Knight skips its next Knight Turn completely: no behaviour check, no roll, no movement, and no encounter that turn.

05

Encounters

At step 10, if you and the Cursed Knight are in the same room (and it isn't stunned), stop and announce: **"THE CURSED KNIGHT FOUND YOU!"** Then choose one option.

RUN

Roll the D6.

1–2 lose 1 Health
3–6 no damage

Then, whatever you rolled: move to 1 adjacent room of your choice, +1 Noise, and that room becomes the Last Known Noise Location.

HIDE

Roll the D6.

1–3 hide fails: lose 1 Health, then move to 1 adjacent room.
4–6 hide succeeds: no damage, and you stay in this room.

Encounter HIDE does **not** change Noise.

USE ITEM

Use your hero's item or a Minor Treasure, if one can be used here (see sections 06–07). Healing items do not end the encounter: after healing you must still RUN or HIDE.

The Rune Key cannot be used in an encounter.

Health. You start with 3 Health and can never have more than 3. If Health reaches 0, the game ends immediately and you lose.

After a successful HIDE the Knight is still in your room. If you are still together after its next turn, it finds you again, so think about moving away on your turn.

RUN or HIDE? RUN has only a 1-in-3 chance of damage but always adds Noise, which can push the Knight into Hunt. HIDE has a 1-in-2 chance of damage but keeps you quiet. In playtests, players who mostly HIDE win more often.

06

Heroes

All four heroes start with **3 Health, 0 Rune Shards and 0 Noise**. None has a passive ability. Each carries exactly **one** single-use item, which is discarded after use. Items can be used at the start of your turn before choosing a card, or at the moment their effect says.

Ranger

Strong emergency escape

`ENCHANTED LANTERN`

The Cursed Knight skips its next Knight Turn.
In an encounter: you also move to 1 adjacent room with no Noise, and the Knight skips its next turn.

Knight

Can save one failed activation

`RUNE KEY`

Use once during ACTIVATE: if you roll exactly **2**, change it to **3**. The activation succeeds and you spend 2 Shards. Not usable in encounters. No permanent bonus.

Mage

Strong Noise control

`SILENCE SCROLL`

Noise –2 (minimum 0).
In an encounter: Noise –2, then move to 1 adjacent room.

Alchemist

Can recover one lost Heart

`HEALING POTION`

Restore 1 Health (never above 3).
In an encounter: heal first, then you still choose RUN or HIDE.

07

Minor Treasures

Rolling a 6 on SEARCH lets you draw 1 Minor Treasure. They are small helpers, weaker than hero items.

- You can carry **at most 1** Minor Treasure. Your hero item doesn't count toward this limit.
- If you find a second one, look at both, keep one and discard the other.
- Each treasure is used once, then discarded. If the treasure pile runs out, shuffle the discarded treasures into a new pile.

TREASURE	EFFECT	WHEN
Ward Charm	Noise –1.	Your turn, or in an encounter (then still RUN or HIDE)
Old Shield	Ignore 1 damage from the Cursed Knight. Discard it as soon as it blocks.	Automatically, the next time you would lose Health
Emergency Ration	Heal 1 Health, **only** if you have exactly 1 Health. Maximum stays 3.	Your turn, or in an encounter (then still RUN or HIDE)
Secret Passage Map	Move 1 more adjacent room. No Noise.	Right after an EXPLORE action

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Rule Clarifications

When does an encounter happen?

Only at step 10, if you share a room with the Knight. Walking into the Knight's room does not start a fight straight away. If it then rolls 1–4 and stays, you meet at step 10.

Knight already in your room

If the Knight is hunting and already in your room, a 5–6 means it simply stays with you.

Arriving at the Noise token

If the Knight reaches the Noise token's room and you are not there, remove the token. It patrols from next turn. If you are there, resolve an encounter.

Using items

You may use any number of items at the start of your turn, before choosing a card. The Rune Key and Secret Passage Map are used at the moment their effect describes. The Old Shield is automatic.

Each Seal only once

A restored Seal can't be activated again, so you cannot play Activate there.

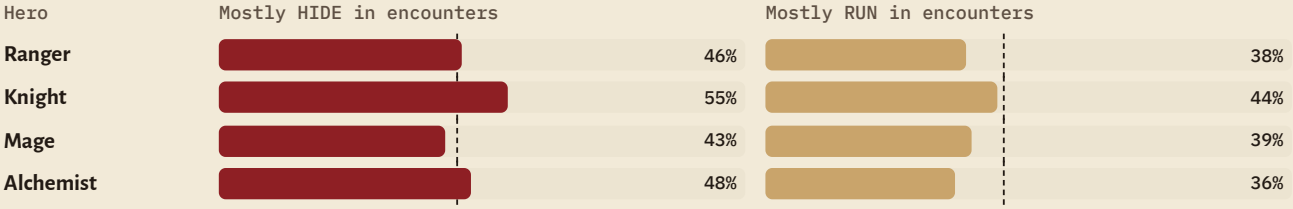
Victory first

If the third Seal is restored, you win immediately. The Knight does not take a turn after that.

09

Balance & Playtest Results

We tested the rules with a computer simulation of a sensible player: 20,000 games per hero, using exactly the rules in this book. The target was a **45–50%** player win rate.



Bars show the player's win rate out of 100%. The dashed line marks 45%, the bottom of the target range.

What the numbers mean

- **On target.** A player who mostly HIDEs wins about 43–48% of games with most heroes.
- **Decisions matter.** Mostly RUNNING costs around 5–12 percentage points, because the extra Noise pushes the Knight into Hunt.
- **Losses come from piled-up risk.** Losses split between running out of Health and running out of turns. A winning game usually ends around Turn 18–19.
- **Minor Treasures help only a little,** about +1 percentage point, as intended.

Watch in paper playtests

- **Knight hero.** It is about 7 points stronger than the others, because running out of time is a common loss and only the Rune Key saves time. If paper playtests agree, one possible fix is to allow the Rune Key only on a Seal you have already failed at once.
- **Learning time.** Check that new players understand Patrol, Investigate and Hunt within about 2 minutes, using the quick reference.
- **Game length.** 24 turns should take 10–15 minutes on paper.

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Quick Reference

Goal

Restore Seals A, B and C (2 Shards each) before Health 0 or the end of Turn 24. Start with 3 Health, 0 Shards, 0 Noise.

Each turn

Draw 2 → choose 1 → discard 1 → resolve → dice → Noise → Knight behaviour → Knight D6 → Knight moves → encounter? → victory? → defeat? → next turn.

Cards (16)

Explore ×5	Move 1. No Noise.
Dash ×2	Move up to 2, then +1 Noise.
Search ×4	1: +1 Noise · 2–3: 1 Shard · 4–5: 2 · 6: 2 + Treasure
Activate ×3	On a Seal with 2+ Shards. 1–2: fail, +1 Noise · 3–5: restored · 6: restored, –1 Noise
Hide ×2	–1 Noise.

Encounter

RUN	1–2: –1 Health. Move 1 room, +1 Noise, token there.
HIDE	1–3: –1 Health, move 1 room. 4–6: safe, stay.
ITEM	Lantern, Scroll, Potion, Charm, Ration. Shield is automatic.

Cursed Knight

D6: 1–4 stays · 5–6 moves 1 room. The direction is never random.

Patrol (Noise 0–2, no token): fixed route Dungeon → Throne Room → Seal A → Forge → Great Hall → Armory → Seal B → Library → Seal C, then back.

Investigate (Noise 0–2, token on map): goes to the token. If you're not there, remove the token and it patrols.

Hunt (Noise 3–5): goes straight to you.

Shortest route; ties go vertical first. When Noise drops from 3+ to 2 or less, put the token on your room.

Noise

+1: Dash, failed Search, failed Activate, RUN.
–1: Hide card, Ward Charm, Activate 6. **–2:** Silence Scroll.
Raising Noise moves the token to your room. Noise 5 gives no bonus Knight move.

Heroes (one item each, one use)

Ranger	Lantern: Knight skips its next turn (in an encounter, also escape 1 room, no Noise).
Knight	Rune Key: Activate roll 2 → 3.
Mage	Silence Scroll: –2 Noise (in an encounter, also escape 1 room).
Alchemist	Potion: +1 Health (max 3).

Treasure (carry 1)

Ward Charm –1 Noise · Old Shield blocks 1 damage · Ration +1 Health at exactly 1 Health · Map: +1 room after Explore.